

Moldova



The most densely populated of the former Soviet republics, Moldova has strong ethnic, linguistic, and cultural links with Romania, but relations with Russia remain paramount.



GEOGRAPHY

Steppes and hilly plains are drained by the Dniester and Prut rivers.



CLIMATE

Warm summers and relatively mild winters. Moderate rainfall is evenly spread throughout the year.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

A shared heritage with Romania defines national identity, though in 1994 Moldovans voted against possible reunification with Romania. Most of the population is engaged in intensive agriculture. Transnistria is a breakaway state along the east bank of the Dniester, home to a largely ethnic Slav population. The Gagauz, in the south, have accepted autonomy.



INSIGHT: *Vast underground wine vaults contain entire "streets" of bottles built into rock quarries*



THE ECONOMY

One of the two poorest countries in Europe. Mainly agricultural: produces wine, tobacco, fruit. Food processing and textiles. Depends on Russia for raw materials, fuel, exports. Instability.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Moldova

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Chisinau

POPULATION: 3.6 million

TOTAL AREA: 13,067 sq. miles
(33,843 sq. km)

DENSITY: 277 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Moldovan*, Ukrainian, Russian

RELIGIONS: Orthodox Christian 98%, Jewish 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Moldovan 64%, Ukrainian 14%, Russian 13%, Gagauz 4%, other 5%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Moldovan leu = 100 bani